The Siren Song of Stephen Jay Gould

By Benjamin Bettenbender

[The bank of a river, near a bridge. A WOMAN walks slowly along the bank, staring across the water. She stops, lost in a moment. She then reaches into her pocket, removes something, hesitates, then pulls her arm back to throw. An anguished cry is heard from above. She stops and looks up when a MAN falls on her, knocking her over. Neither moves for a moment. Then the man slowly disengages himself and stands, placing his left foot down gingerly, wincing; he then looks back to her]

MAN: Oh my God. *[moves to her side, touching her lightly on the arm]* Are you all right? Miss? *[Shaking her]* Miss, are you all right?

WOMAN: Oowwww! What did you do? *[Trying to move her right arm]* I think my arm is broken.

MAN: Oh God! Um ... Move your fingers. That's how you tell if your arm is broken.

WOMAN: No it's not. That's how you tell if your fingers are broken!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Here's a story for you . . . Two friends are watching television when the news comes on. It shows a guy on a bridge about to jump, obviously suicidal.*
ACTRESS: *(watching television) I'll bet you $10 he'll jump.*
ACTOR: *(watching television) Bet you $10 he won't.*
ACTRESS: *Then, the guy closes his eyes and throws himself off the bridge. (to Actor) I can't take your money. I cheated you. The same story was on the six o'clock news.*
ACTOR: *No. Take it. I saw the six o'clock news too. I just didn't think the guy would be stupid enough to jump again!*
ACTRESS: *While suicide is never funny . . . Benjamin Bettenbender takes a lighthearted look at an attempted suicide in*
TOGETHER: *The Siren Song of Stephen Jay Gould*

MAN: Here, sit up. *[tries to help her, but she shrugs him off. She removes the object she had been holding in her injured hand and places it back in her pocket. She extends her arm out in staring at her fingers]* Try to move them.

WOMAN: I am. They're shaking and you're bleeding!

MAN: *[Dabbing at his forehead]* Is it bad?

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WOMAN: Just a little cut. . . . Can I ask you something? I'm a little woozy so I apologize if this sounds strange, but did you jump on me?

MAN: Well, I wasn't ... I didn't exactly, no.

WOMAN: Did you fall? Were you thrown?

MAN: I leapt.

WOMAN: I see. Then when you said no, what you really meant was yes, you ***did*** jump on me.

MAN: I didn't even see you.

WOMAN: I was standing right here. Didn't you check first?

MAN: I should have. It was irresponsible of me, but I thought I was over the water.

WOMAN: The water's way over there. It's low because of the drought. You ***jumped*** on me! How dare you?!

MAN: I'm really, ***really*** sorry.

WOMAN: You could have killed me. All because you couldn't bother to look before leaping off a bridge. And what kind of dunderhead goes swimming dressed like that? In jeans. And spats.

MAN: They're not spats. They're ankle weights.

WOMAN: Oh great. Even better. Why not strap a millstone around your neck? That way you can be sure to ... *[She stops, stares at him]* Tell me this isn't what it looks like. You weren't jumping ...

MAN: To my death, yes. *[Long pause. She then bursts out laughing]* Hey!

WOMAN: Off that little bridge. *[laughs harder]* With those things on your feet, without even checking to ... *[laughs even more]* Even if you hit the water, it would barely come up to your waist. *[laughs]* You'd be standing stuck in the mud with those ankle thingies on, trying to pull them out. *[mimes pulling a leg out of the mud]* Ssssclorp! *[laughs]*

MAN: All right, that's enough. I mean it! This isn't something you make fun of.

WOMAN: You mean trying to drown yourself in a puddle? *[Suddenly serious- mimics him]* I was leaping into the mud ... to my death. *[laughs]*

MAN: I was trying to go head first, for your information, but the ankle weights swung me around so my feet . . . *[She laughs harder than ever]* That's it. I'm not talking to you.

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[starts to limp off]

WOMAN: Wait, I'm sorry. You're hurt. I won't laugh anymore. *[He stops, limps over to her, holds out his hand to help her up]* So why were you jumping?

MAN: I told you.

WOMAN: Yeah, but why? Depressed? You don't seem it. Depression is a medical condition with a recognizable set of symptoms. I don't see any.

MAN: That's because I'm irritated right now.

WOMAN: There you go. People in a suicidal depression don't get irritated. They're apathetic.

MAN: *[apathetic]* Whatever.

WOMAN: That's why I thought it might be something else: an illness, bad news, a loss, fear.

MAN: No.

WOMAN: Guilt.

MAN: Over what?

WOMAN: How should I know. Maybe you got into an argument and beat someone into a coma and found out later he was a Zen Buddhist who had taken a vow of nonviolence and couldn't defend himself, and he had six kids and was working on a cure for blindness. Or maybe, ***maybe***, it's love. Maybe you're heartbroken over a romance that ended. Or that never was.

MAN: What's so bad about that?

WOMAN: Are you kidding? That's about the best reason to drown yourself. Meeting the person you want to be with forever and then realizing it can never be. Knowing you'll grow old and die without ever again looking into the one set of eyes that brings peace to your heart.

MAN: But you just said I didn't seem depressed.

WOMAN: That's not depression. That's something far more profound. I don't think you quite understand what I'm getting at.

MAN: What's not to understand? You like someone, they don't like you back. Woe-dee-woo-dee-woo. You mope around a few days, play around with the idea of killing yourself just to show them how sorry they'll be when you're gone, then you get bored with it all, get

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interested in someone else, and ffffffft! It's all better. *[sees her staring at him]* What? What is it? What?

WOMAN: I don't want to discuss this anymore.

MAN: But you brought it up.

WOMAN: That's before I realized you lacked the emotional sophistication to understand what true loss is. I should have guessed it, though, judging by your pathetic, halfhearted attempt to kill yourself.

MAN: Pathetic?! Hell! Listen, you judgmental. . . whatever, if we had gotten even half the rainfall we usually do, I'd be dead right now! Dragged to the bottom of a dark river with my lungs filled with water and you'd have been on the shore watching the whole thing, thinking how depressed and emotionally sophisticated I was to have done it!

WOMAN: But you didn't, did you? And you want to know why you didn't? Because you're too shallow. Because you never experienced pain so strong it would make eternal darkness seem like a bargain by comparison.

MAN: Oh, and you have, I suppose? Then why are you here talking about it? Why aren't you floating around in eternal darkness all happy and carefree?

WOMAN: Listen, I was close. I was this close.

MAN: What, you gave your wrist a little scratch? Took a few too many aspirin?

WOMAN: I drank poison, bucko!

MAN: You're so committed, tell me what kind of poison you drank. Maybe I'll go buy some. *[pause]* Well?

WOMAN: What I drank -- in the firm belief that I was, in fact, ending my life -- even though it was extremely dangerous in large doses, wasn't ***technically*** poison.

MAN: So what was it? Buttermilk? *[pause]*

WOMAN: Ipecac. . . I drank ipecac!

MAN: But that's the stuff that makes you-

WOMAN: I know what it is ***now****!* I know better than anyone. But before that I had been told never to touch it, and my folks kept it on the top shelf of their medicine cabinet hidden in back, so I thought it must be lethal.

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MAN: I bet it felt lethal. *[laughs]*

WOMAN: You have no idea. *[pause]* Well, I'm not going to make the same mistake again. As soon as I've completed a sweet, symbolic gesture, I'm going to do it right.

MAN: What'll it be this time, death by Ex-lax? *[She stares at him]* What? You get to make fun of me, but I can't say the least little thing about you? *[pause, then he confesses]* Stephen Jay Gould -- he's this scientist up at Harvard.

WOMAN: *[excitedly jumps to a conclusion]* He flunked you and you had to drop out of school and it ruined your life. No wait, wait! He stole your research and published it and got famous and married your girlfriend, and you ended up broke and alone and bitter. *[pause while he stares at her]* Maybe you should just tell it.

MAN: He's an author. He writes about trilobites and dinosaurs, stuff like that . . . but he's ***really*** talking about how people are this big accident. How most life on earth is bacteria, and how everything else is just sort of ... ***not*** bacteria.

WOMAN: So?

MAN: Well, the way he explained it made sense. I could see that life was pretty much just a lot of microbes swimming in the dirt, and all the things we see around us and find beautiful and live for are just a fluke. I read his book and it made everything seem... pointless. Look, I'll get you a copy. See for yourself.

WOMAN: Actually, I'm surprised he was even able to write the thing in the first place. Seems like once he figured out how tiny and random he was, he would've nose-dived straight into the Charles.

MAN: Hah! Fat chance. You don't have a great job and a nice house and a wife and some kids and lots of money and a car with leather seats and a great watch and 20 pairs of pants and really cool sunglasses, and then just go and check out. No, I'll tell you when you check out. When your life is so crappy you embarrass yourself just thinking about it, but you keep at it because you figure it must be "For A Reason," and then you read some rich idiot's book telling you how you're really just some tick on the ass of an elephant, and what's left?!

WOMAN: I see. *[pause]* So what now? What are you going to do?

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MAN: Oh. I don't know. Try something else, I guess. Or maybe wait to see if we get some rain. I kind of had my heart set on the bridge thing.

WOMAN: You might want to try a bigger bridge this time.

MAN: I guess. *[pause]* What about you? What are your plans?

WOMAN: I don't know. I had this thing I wanted to do, and now I'm not sure when I'll be able to do it. *[removes a small box from her pocket]* I was going to throw this into the river.

MAN: What is it, a ring?

WOMAN: A ring ***box***, yes.

MAN: But not the ring?

WOMAN: I decided that it would be a sin to throw something of real value away. And since the box is technically what he presented me with, it would be fine if I just tossed that. . . But I throw with my right hand.

MAN: Oh. *[pause]* I could do it for you.

WOMAN: All right then. Chuck away. *[He takes the box from her, hops on his good leg a couple of steps and launches it]* Thank you.

MAN: Feel better? Maybe you won't have to ... you know ... If you're feeling better. *[they begin walking and hobbling down the path as the conversation continues]*

WOMAN: You mean killing myself? You think I change my mind that easy? Toss away one little ring box and everything I'm feeling just flies away with it?

MAN: No, I just thought-- I mean, if you wanted to -- if it wasn't too weird, because I know it's this big personal thing -- but if you wanted ...

WOMAN: *[stopping; looking at him]* Are you asking me to jump ***with*** you?

MAN: I mean, I know bridges aren't for everyone.

WOMAN: No, the bridge is fine. I'm just not sure when I'll be doing it. . .

MAN: You could call me and let me know.

WOMAN: *[hesitates then broaches a new idea]* What about seeing a show instead?

MAN: *[a bit shocked, but excited]* **T**hat's a great idea. And a ball game, a museum, anything you wanted! *[they continue walking]*

WOMAN: I don't know. I'll have to think about it. *[pause]* But it might be nice.

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AWARD HISTORY

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